

## MODULE 4

# Hours of Service, ELD & Feasibility

Can this driver legally and realistically pick up and deliver on time?

The four hours-of-service clocks, the log grid and the ELD, the cycle and restart, the sleeper split, the special rules, and a step-by-step feasibility method used on real lanes — including the Joliet → Charlotte load from Module 0.

**4**

clocks to master

**3**

trip plans worked out

**~7 hours**

study + cases

**20**

booking cases

# How to use this module

In Module 3 you learned **where** a load goes and **when** the appointment is. Now you learn whether the **driver** can legally do it. A load that breaks hours-of-service rules is not a load, however well it pays.

## Study rhythm (about 7 hours)

- **Session 1 (2 h):** the four clocks. Learn them until you can explain each in one sentence.
- **Session 2 (1.5 h):** the log grid and the ELD. Read both example days line by line.
- **Session 3 (2 h):** the feasibility formula and the three trip plans.
- **Session 4 (1.5 h):** the 20 booking cases, the drill and the check.



### Correction to your OMNITECH manual

The manual says a solo driver can legally do “600 legal miles / 10 hr.” **That is not the law.** The law limits **hours**, not miles: 11 hours of driving inside a 14-hour window, a 30-minute break after 8 hours of driving, and a 60/70-hour cycle. In practice a solo driver averages about **500–550 miles** on a good day.

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## After this module you can

- Explain the 11, 14, 30-minute and 70-hour rules
- Read a driver’s ELD clocks and log grid
- Calculate a legal ETA for a 1–3 day trip
- Say “yes”, “no” or “only if...” to a load
- Recognise coercion and refuse to take part



#### MODULE 4 · HOS, ELD & FEASIBILITY

## The driver's clock decides what you can book

Hours-of-service (HOS) rules exist because tired drivers cause crashes. Every U.S. truck driver in interstate commerce works under them, and most record their hours on an electronic logging device (ELD) like the one pictured. As a dispatcher you never touch the logs, but you must plan every load inside them.

# The four clocks

## The four clocks every dispatcher watches

FMCSA hours-of-service rules for property-carrying drivers (trucks). Every load you book must fit inside all four.



Source: FMCSA Summary of Hours of Service Regulations. Pilot programs testing more flexible splits start in 2027; the rules above apply to everyone else.

## The FMCSA rules, word for word (property carriers)

- **11-hour driving limit:** “May drive a maximum of 11 hours after 10 consecutive hours off duty.”
- **14-hour limit:** “May not drive beyond the 14th consecutive hour after coming on duty, following 10 consecutive hours off duty.”
- **30-minute break:** required “when they have driven for a period of 8 cumulative hours without at least a 30-minute interruption.”
- **60/70-hour limit:** “May not drive after 60/70 hours on duty in 7/8 consecutive days.” A 34-hour off-duty period restarts it.



### Memorise it as one sentence

**“After 10 off: 11 driving, inside 14, break after 8, and never over 70 in 8.”**



### Pilot programs are not new rules

In August 2026 FMCSA announced two pilot programs (a flexible sleeper split and a way to pause the 14-hour window for up to 3 hours). Pre-tests ran in 2026 with a handful of drivers; a full test with 512 drivers is planned for 2027.

**The rules on this page still apply to everyone else.**

# 11 and 14: the two daily limits

## The 11-hour driving limit

Counts only **driving** time. After 10 consecutive hours off, the driver has 11 hours of driving. When they are used up, he can still do other work (fuel, paperwork) but **cannot drive** until he takes another 10 hours off.

## The 14-hour window

Starts when the driver first comes **on duty** (any work, not just driving) and runs for 14 hours straight. **It does not stop** for breaks, meals, waiting or loading. After the 14th hour, no more driving until 10 hours off.

## Three worked examples

| The driver's day                                                                   | 11-hour clock                 | 14-hour clock       | Result                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| On duty 06:00, drives 11 h with a 30-min break and 1 h of other work, off at 18:30 | 11 h used — limit reached     | Window closes 20:00 | <b>Legal.</b> Stopped by the 11-hour limit.                             |
| On duty 06:00, waits 5 h at the shipper, drives from 13:30                         | Can drive until 20:00 = 6.5 h | Window closes 20:00 | <b>Stopped by the 14-hour window</b> with 2.5 h of driving unused.      |
| On duty 05:00, drives 4 h, 1 h breakfast off duty, drives 7 h                      | 11 h at 17:00 (break taken)   | Window closes 19:00 | <b>Legal.</b> The breakfast hour counted toward the window, not the 11. |



### The question that matters most

When a driver says “I have 8 hours,” ask: **“8 hours of driving, or 8 hours left in your shift?”** They are different clocks, and the smaller one decides.

## Why the 14-hour window is the real limit

The window keeps running during breaks, waiting and loading. Lost hours in the window are lost driving.



# The 30-minute break

## What triggers it

**8 cumulative hours of driving** without an interruption of at least 30 consecutive minutes. Cumulative means driving time adds up across stops shorter than 30 minutes: 3 h + 15-min fuel stop + 5 h = 8 h, and a break is now due.

## What counts as the break

Any **30 consecutive minutes** not driving: off duty, sleeper berth, **or on duty not driving** (e.g. loading), or a mix taken back to back. So a 45-minute loading stop after 6 hours of driving resets the 8-hour count.

| Sequence                             | Break needed?                                   |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Drive 5 h → load 1 h → drive 5 h     | <b>No</b> — loading 1 h interrupted the driving |
| Drive 4 h → fuel 20 min → drive 4 h  | <b>Yes</b> — 20 min is too short; 8 h reached   |
| Drive 8 h straight                   | <b>Yes</b> — 30 min before more driving         |
| Drive 7 h → sleeper 10 h → drive 7 h | <b>No</b> — the rest period reset everything    |



### Planning shortcut

For plans, add **30 minutes for every 8 hours of driving**, unless a stop at a shipper or receiver already gives the driver 30 minutes.

## Where breaks fit in a real day

| Situation                 | How the break is handled                                         | Dispatcher tip                              |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| <b>Long run, no stops</b> | Driver stops at a truck stop or rest area after ≤ 8 h of driving | Add 30 min to the ETA                       |
| <b>Pickup mid-day</b>     | 30+ min of loading counts as the break                           | No extra time needed                        |
| <b>Fuel + meal stop</b>   | If 30 consecutive minutes, it is the break                       | Suggest combining them                      |
| <b>Parking at night</b>   | Truck parking is scarce in many areas after dark                 | Plan the rest stop before the window closes |



### Truck parking is a real constraint

A driver whose window closes at 20:00 must be **parked** by then, not just “near” a truck stop. On the East Coast and near big cities, truck stops can be full by early evening. Ask the driver where he plans to park.

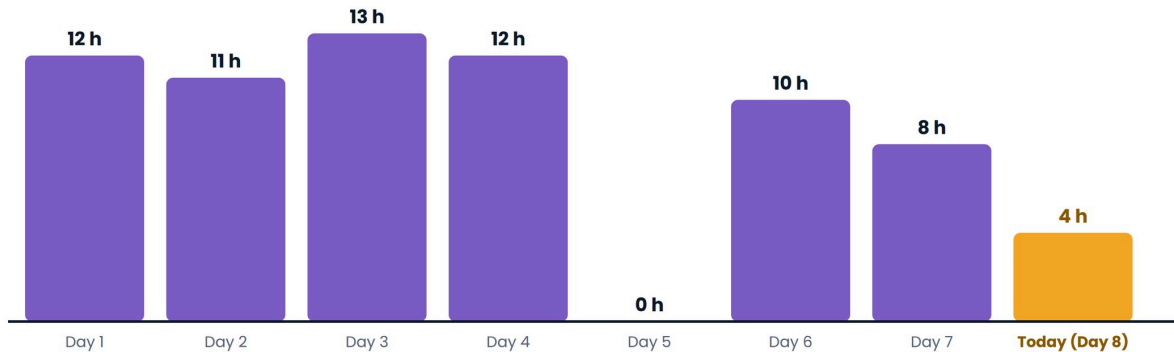
# The weekly limit: 60/7 or 70/8

## The 70-hour / 8-day cycle

A weekly limit on top of the daily clocks. A driver with a great daily clock can still be out of cycle hours.

**Last 7 days on duty:**  $12+11+13+12+0+10+8 = 66 \text{ h}$

Hours left today under 70/8 =  $70 - 66 = 4 \text{ h}$ . Tomorrow Day 1 (12 h) drops off and gives hours back.



**Rolling total.** Every day, the oldest day falls off and the new day is added. The ELD shows the "cycle" hours left.

**34-hour restart.** 34+ consecutive hours off duty resets the cycle to a full 70 h. Many drivers take it at home on weekends.

## Which one applies?

A carrier that does **not** operate every day of the week uses 60 hours in 7 days. A carrier that operates **every day** may use 70 hours in 8 days. Most long-haul carriers use **70/8**. The ELD knows which one the driver is on.

**All on-duty time counts** toward the cycle, driving and non-driving (loading, waiting, inspections).



### Why dispatchers watch the cycle

A driver with only 4 cycle hours left can't take a 10-hour trip today, however fresh he feels. On a Friday you may need to plan a **34-hour restart** at home, or give hours back by planning short days.



### Try it

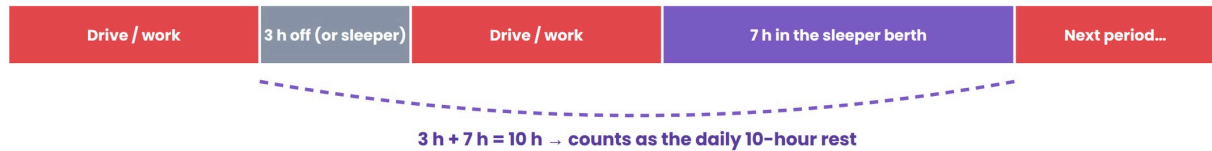
A driver has worked 11, 12, 10, 13, 0, 9, 11 hours in the last 7 days (70/8). How many hours can he work today? (Answer at the back.)

# The sleeper-berth split

## The sleeper-berth split (advanced)

Drivers with a sleeper cab can split the 10-hour rest into two parts. Useful around long waits — but always plan it WITH the driver.

Illustration — hours not to scale with a real day



Allowed pairings: at least 7 h in the sleeper + at least 2 h off/sleeper (e.g. 7/3, 8/2), total ≥ 10 h.  
Used together, neither rest period counts against the 14-hour window.

**Beginner rule:** never assume a split. Ask the driver: “Are you planning a split?” The ELD calculates the clocks; don’t argue with it.

## The rule in plain words

A driver with a sleeper berth can split the 10-hour rest into two periods: one of **at least 7 consecutive hours in the sleeper berth**, and another of **at least 2 hours** (off duty or sleeper). Together they must add up to **at least 10 hours**. When paired correctly, neither period counts against the 14-hour window.

FMCSA’s summary lists the pairings: 7/3, 8/2, 7.5/2.5 and so on.



### How dispatchers use it

A driver stuck for 3 hours at a slow shipper might log that time in the sleeper and use it as the short half of a split. That can save a delivery. But the **calculation belongs to the driver and his ELD**. You ask; you don’t decide.



### Beginner mistake

Planning a trip that only works “if he splits” without asking the driver. Many drivers dislike splits because the sleep is broken. Plan on a normal 10-hour rest unless the driver offers a split.

# Adverse conditions, short-haul, PC and yard moves

## Special rules you will hear about

Know they exist and what they are for. Don't build a plan around them without the driver and carrier.



### Adverse driving conditions

Unexpected snow, fog, road closure, crash: the 11-h and 14-h limits can be extended by up to 2 hours.

Not for conditions known before the trip started, and not for normal traffic.



### Short-haul exception

Drivers who stay within a 150 air-mile radius and finish within 14 hours can use time records instead of logs (and no ELD).

Mostly local / regional box-truck work.



### Personal conveyance

Off-duty use of the truck, e.g. to a nearby safe place to rest after the shipper makes the driver leave.

Never to move freight closer to delivery.



### Yard moves

Moving the truck inside a yard or terminal. Logged as on duty.

Not a way to add driving time on public roads.

| Rule                              | Plain meaning                                                                                                                            | Dispatcher note                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Adverse driving conditions</b> | 11-h and 14-h limits can be extended by up to 2 hours for conditions the driver didn't know about when he started (snow, fog, a closure) | Never plan a trip that depends on it                                                     |
| <b>Short-haul exception</b>       | Within 150 air miles, back within 14 hours: time records instead of logs                                                                 | Common for local box trucks. Ask the carrier which drivers use it                        |
| <b>Personal conveyance</b>        | Off-duty personal movement of the truck                                                                                                  | Never to advance a load; FMCSA guidance allows e.g. moving to the nearest safe rest spot |
| <b>Yard move</b>                  | Movement inside a yard, logged as on duty                                                                                                | Not for public roads                                                                     |

# The rules on one page

| Rule                      | Limit                                            | Resets with                                       |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Driving</b>            | 11 h                                             | 10 consecutive hours off (or valid sleeper split) |
| <b>Window</b>             | No driving after the 14th hour on duty           | 10 consecutive hours off (or valid split)         |
| <b>Break</b>              | 30 min after 8 cumulative hours of driving       | Any 30 consecutive minutes not driving            |
| <b>Cycle</b>              | 60 h / 7 days or 70 h / 8 days on duty           | Rolling; or a 34-hour off-duty restart            |
| <b>Sleeper split</b>      | $\geq 7$ h sleeper + $\geq 2$ h, total $\geq 10$ | —                                                 |
| <b>Adverse conditions</b> | + up to 2 h on the 11 and 14                     | Unexpected conditions only                        |
| <b>Short-haul</b>         | 150 air miles, 14-hour day                       | Time records instead of logs                      |

## Miles per day, realistically

**≈ 500–550**

**miles on a full solo day:** 11 h × about 50 mph average including towns, traffic and fuel.

**≈ 350–450**

**miles on a day with a pickup or delivery,** because stops eat into the 14-hour window.

**≈ 1,000+**

**miles per 24 h for a team,** two drivers taking turns, each within his own limits.



### Why “600 miles a day” is dangerous

If you promise a broker 600+ miles a day for a solo driver, the trip only works if he speeds, skips breaks or falsifies his logs. Plan on 500–550 on full driving days and less on pickup and delivery days.

# What an ELD is and what it records

## The ELD: statuses and what the device does

An electronic logging device plugs into the truck's engine and records the driver's duty status and driving automatically.



Real photo: an ELD tablet and engine connector, from your OMNITECH manual.

**Who must use one:** most drivers who must keep records of duty status. Exceptions include short-haul drivers using time cards, drivers on paper logs ≤ 8 days in any 30, drive-away/tow-away, and vehicles built before 2000.



### Off duty

Rest, meals, personal time. Not working.



### Driving

Recorded automatically once the truck moves (about 5 mph).



### Personal conveyance (PC)

Off-duty use of the truck for personal reasons — never to move a load forward.



### Sleeper berth

Resting in the truck's sleeper cab.



### On duty, not driving

Pre-trip inspection, loading, fuelling, waiting at docks, paperwork.



### Yard move (YM)

Moving the truck inside a yard or terminal — on duty.

## How it works

The ELD connects to the truck's engine. When the truck moves, it switches the driver to **Driving** automatically and records time, location and engine data. The driver selects the other statuses. Officers at roadside inspections can view or receive the logs.

Carriers usually give dispatchers a login to the ELD provider's **web portal**, where you can see every driver's clocks and location.



### If the ELD breaks (49 CFR 395.34)

The driver notes the malfunction, notifies the carrier in writing within 24 hours, rebuilds his logs on paper for today and the previous 7 days, and keeps paper logs until the ELD is fixed. The carrier has 8 days to repair or replace it.



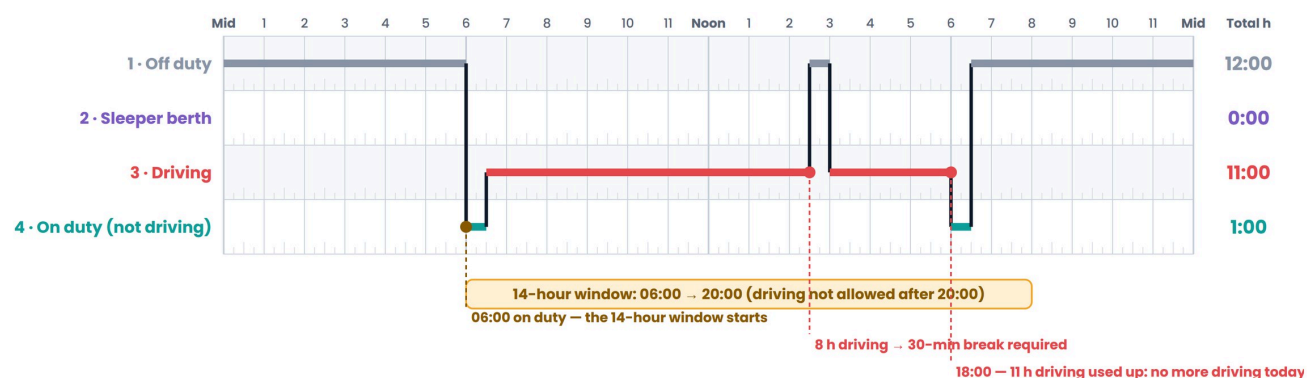
### You read the ELD; you never edit it

Drivers can propose edits for genuine mistakes (e.g. forgot to switch to off duty), and the ELD keeps the original record. **Asking a driver to change his hours so a load "works" is illegal.**

## Reading the log grid

## A legal driving day on the log grid

This is how an ELD shows the day (the classic four-line graph). Read it left to right, midnight to midnight.



**Totals:** 11 h driving (the maximum) · 1 h on duty · 12 h off. The driver ran out of **driving hours** at 18:00, before the 14-hour window closed at 20:00. He needs 10 h off before driving again.

## How to read it

- Four rows: **off duty, sleeper berth, driving, on duty not driving.**
- The line moves between rows as the driver's status changes; the grid covers 24 hours, midnight to midnight.
- Totals on the right always add up to **24:00**.
- Times follow the driver's **home-terminal** time zone (49 CFR 395.8), which may differ from the local time of the stop.



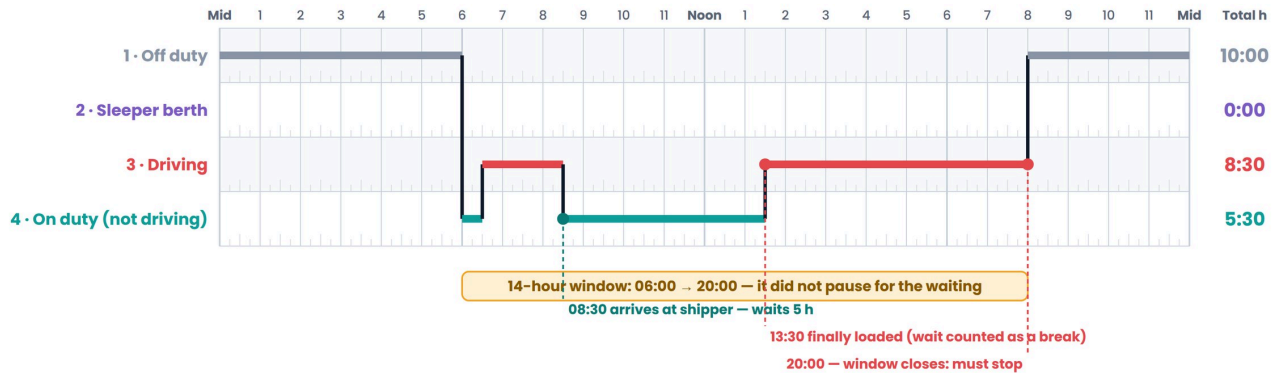
## Read this day

When did the 14-hour window start and end? When was the break taken, and why then? How many driving hours were left at 18:00? (Answers are on the graph itself.)

# Same driver, same window — 5 hours of waiting

## The same driver, with 5 hours of detention

Waiting at a dock is on-duty time. The 14-hour window keeps running while the driver waits.



**Totals:** only **8.5 h driving** — 2.5 h of driving lost (≈ 125 miles). This is why dispatchers ask about **detention**, and why a late loading can make a next-day delivery impossible.

## What the detention cost

He waited 5 hours on duty at the shipper, so the window closed at 20:00 with only 8.5 hours of driving done. That is about **125 miles fewer** than planned. If tomorrow's delivery assumed a full day of driving, it is now late.



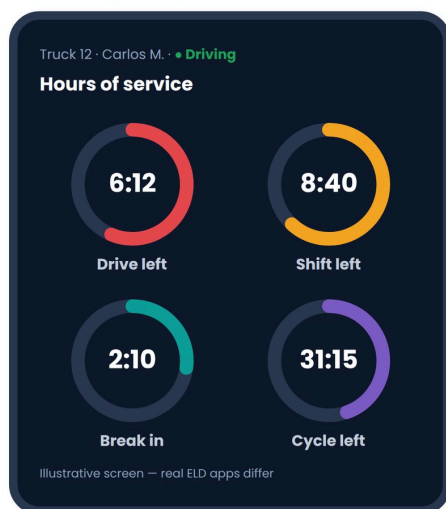
### What you do when detention starts

1 · Note the arrival time (and get proof: check-in slip, ELD location). 2 · Tell the broker when the RC's free time is running out. 3 · **Re-plan the next appointment** immediately using the hours actually left. Detention pay comes in Module 10.

# Four numbers before every booking

## Reading a driver's hours on an ELD app

Carriers can give dispatchers access to the ELD portal. You read four numbers before every booking.



### Drive left 6:12

He can drive about 6 more hours today ( $\approx 300$  miles at 50 mph).

### Shift left 8:40

His 14-hour window closes in 8 h 40 min.

### Break in 2:10

After 2 h 10 min more driving he needs a 30-min break.

### Cycle left 31:15

About 31 h of on-duty time left this 8-day cycle.

**The binding clock** is the smallest one that matters for the trip. Here: 6:12 of driving, but a break is due after 2:10.

## How to ask when you have no portal access



### Say it out loud — asking for hours

**“Hi Carlos, before I book tomorrow’s load: how many drive hours and shift hours do you have left right now, and how much on your 70? When does your break come due?”**



### Write them down with the time

“Carlos, Tue 21:10 PKT: drive 6:12 · shift 8:40 · break in 2:10 · cycle 31:15.” The clocks change every minute; the note shows when you asked.

## What the four numbers let you do

| Number            | Question it answers                            | Example use                                          |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Drive left</b> | How far can he drive today?                    | $6:12 \times 50 \approx 300$ miles more today        |
| <b>Shift left</b> | When must he stop, even with drive hours left? | Can he still load (1.5 h) and then drive?            |
| <b>Break in</b>   | When is a 30-min stop due?                     | Add 30 min to the ETA if no loading stop comes first |
| <b>Cycle left</b> | Can he do a multi-day trip this week?          | A 3-day trip needs $\approx 30+$ on-duty hours       |

# The feasibility formula

## The feasibility formula

Can this driver legally and realistically pick up and deliver on time? Run this before you call the broker.

|                                                                                   |                     |                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  | <b>Driving time</b> | <b>miles ÷ 50 mph</b><br>A common planning average (traffic, fuel, towns). Some fleets use 45–55.                               |
|  | <b>Breaks</b>       | <b>+ 0.5 h per 8 h of driving</b><br>Or none if loading/waiting already gave 30 min.                                            |
|  | <b>Daily rest</b>   | <b>+ 10 h off after 11 h driving or when the 14-h window closes</b><br>≈ 500–550 miles per legal driving day for a solo driver. |
|  | <b>Stops</b>        | <b>+ time at shipper / receiver</b><br>Often 1–2 h; much more with detention. Ask.                                              |
|  | <b>Buffer</b>       | <b>+ 1–2 h (or more in winter)</b><br>Weather, traffic, city delivery, mountains.                                               |
|  | <b>Compare</b>      | <b>– ETA in the RECEIVER'S time zone vs the appointment</b><br>Also check cycle hours and the driver's current clocks.          |

## The method in one line

**Start time + stop time + driving (miles ÷ 50) + breaks + rest periods + buffer = ETA.** Convert the ETA to the **receiver's time zone** and compare with the appointment. Then check that the driver's current clocks and cycle allow it.



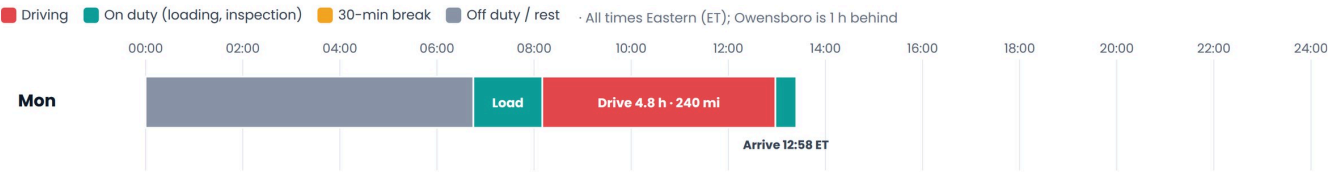
### Why 50 mph?

Trucks often cruise at 60–70 mph on interstates, but fuel stops, towns, traffic, weigh stations and construction bring the real average down. 50 mph is a common, safe planning figure. Some carriers use 45 (cities, mountains) or 55 (open highway).

# A one-day trip: load #12354

## Feasibility: load #12354, Lebanon, OH → Owensboro, KY (240 mi)

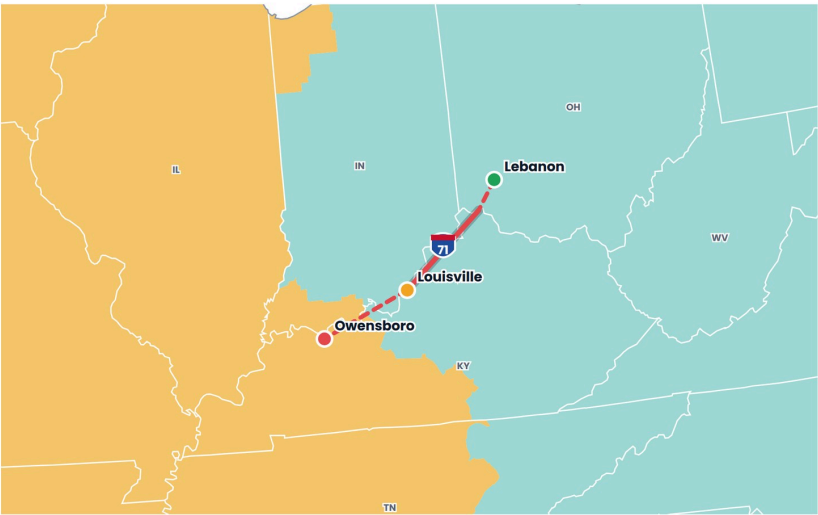
PU 7–8 AM ET · DEL 12:00 PM CT (= 1:00 PM ET). Plan shown in Eastern Time.



**Result:** arrival ≈ 12:58 PM ET = **11:58 AM CT** for a 12:00 PM CT appointment. **Zero buffer.** A dispatcher should warn the broker early, or ask the receiver for a later window before booking.

## Load #12354 on the map: Lebanon, OH → Owensboro, KY

The Module 1 load. Short and west-south-west — and it crosses from Eastern into Central Time.



|            |                                                |
|------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Direction  | West-south-west                                |
| Main roads | I-71 toward Louisville, then west to Owensboro |
| Distance   | 240 miles on the RC                            |
| Time zones | Lebanon = Eastern · Owensboro = Central        |
| Clock      | Goes BACK 1 hour during the trip               |
| Delivery   | 12 PM CT = 1 PM ET = 11 PM PKT (Feb)           |

Map colours = time zones. Route simplified; the driver's truck GPS / routing tool decides the exact road.

| Step            | Calculation                                                | Result                                        |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Load at shipper | On duty 6:45 ET, BOL printed 7:55, leave ≈ 8:10            | Depart 8:10 AM ET                             |
| Drive           | 240 mi ÷ 50 mph = 4.8 h                                    | Arrive ≈ 12:58 PM ET                          |
| Convert         | ET → CT: minus 1 h                                         | <b>11:58 AM CT</b> vs 12:00 PM CT appointment |
| Clocks          | ≈ 6 h on duty, 4.8 h driving: no break needed, window fine | <b>Legal — but no buffer</b>                  |

# A two-day trip: Joliet → Charlotte

## Feasibility: Joliet, IL → Charlotte, NC (≈ 790 mi)

PU Wed 9:00 AM CT · DEL Thu 2:00 PM ET. Driver starts the day with full clocks.



**Result:** arrival ≈ 12:48 PM CT = **1:48 PM ET** for a 2:00 PM ET appointment. **Legal, but only a 12-minute buffer.** Ask for a later delivery time or an earlier pickup before booking, and tell the carrier the risk.

| Step       | Calculation (Central Time)                 | Result                                     |
|------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Wed pickup | On duty 8:30, loaded 9:00–10:30            | Depart 10:30 · window closes 22:30         |
| Drive 1    | 8 h = 400 mi → 18:30; 30-min break → 19:00 | 400 mi done                                |
| Drive 2    | 3 h = 150 mi → 22:00 (11 h driving used)   | 550 mi done · stop                         |
| Rest       | 10 h off: 22:00 → 08:00 Thu                | Clocks reset                               |
| Drive 3    | 240 mi ÷ 50 = 4.8 h → 12:48 CT             | <b>1:48 PM ET arrival</b>                  |
| Compare    | Appointment Thu 2:00 PM ET                 | <b>Legal, 12-minute buffer — too tight</b> |



### What you do with a tight plan

Before booking, ask the broker: **“Can we get a 4 PM delivery, or FCFS until 5?”** or propose an earlier pickup. If the broker can’t move it, tell the carrier exactly how tight it is and let them decide.



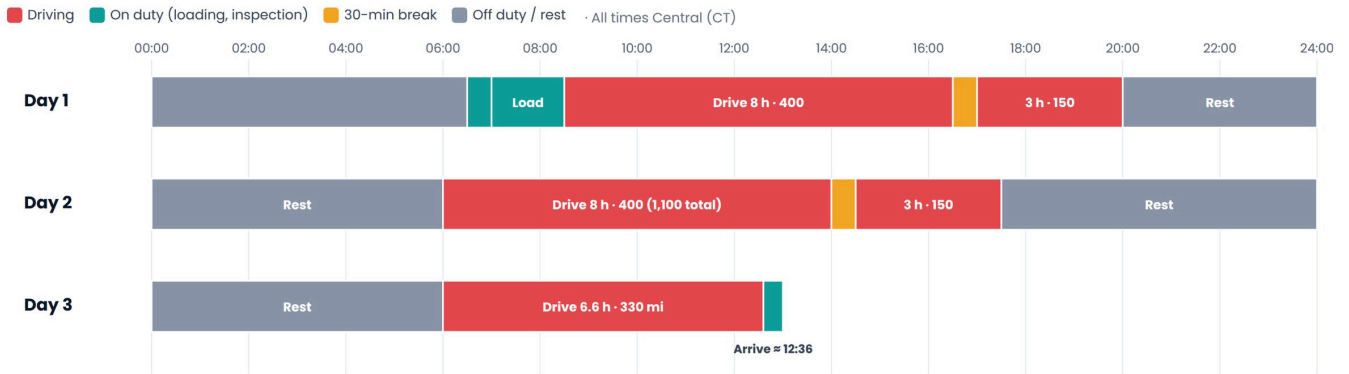
### This fixes the Module 0 message

Mike’s message said “DEL Thu 2 PM” for a 750–800-mile trip picked up Wed 9 AM. Now you can see why that answer is risky: only minutes of buffer, and I-77 through the mountains in winter.

# A three-day trip: Laredo → Chicago

## Feasibility: Laredo, TX → Chicago, IL (≈ 1,430 mi)

A 3-day trip for a solo driver. All in Central Time.



**Result:** earliest realistic delivery ≈ **Day 3 around 12:30–1:00 PM CT**. An appointment on Day 2 is **impossible** for a solo driver; it needs a team. Cycle check: ≈ 31 on-duty hours over three days, so the driver needs enough 70-hour cycle left.

## How to estimate long trips fast

1. Divide the miles into full driving days of about **550 miles** (11 h × 50).
2. Reduce the first day for loading (and the last for unloading).
3. Add a **10-hour rest** between days.
4. 1,430 mi → 550 + 550 + 330 = **3 driving days**.



### When a broker asks for the impossible

“Pick up Laredo Monday, deliver Chicago Tuesday” is ~1,430 miles in about 30 hours. That is **team** freight. Say so politely: *“That’s a team transit. With a solo driver the earliest is Wednesday midday.”*



### Team drivers

Two drivers take turns: one drives up to 11 h while the other rests in the sleeper. A team can cover 1,000+ miles in 24 hours. Only offer team service if the carrier really has a team.

# Yes, no, or “only if...”

| Your calculation shows...                                                 | Decision              | What you say / do                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>ETA well before the appointment</b> (2 h+ buffer), clocks and cycle OK | <b>YES</b>            | Proceed to negotiate and book.                                         |
| <b>ETA within 1 h of the appointment</b>                                  | <b>ONLY IF</b>        | Ask for a later appointment or FCFS window; tell the carrier the risk. |
| <b>ETA after the appointment</b>                                          | <b>NO</b> (as posted) | “Can the delivery move to...?” If not, don’t book.                     |
| <b>Driver can’t reach pickup on time</b> with his current hours           | <b>NO</b>             | Don’t promise it. Offer the realistic pickup time.                     |
| <b>Not enough cycle hours</b>                                             | <b>NO</b> or re-plan  | Plan a restart or a shorter load.                                      |
| <b>Only works with a split, team or adverse-conditions extension</b>      | <b>ONLY IF</b>        | Only if the driver or carrier confirms it is real and safe.            |



## The honest-ETA habit

Brokers remember dispatchers whose trucks arrive when promised. It is better to lose a load by being honest than to book a load that arrives late, costs a fee, and damages the carrier’s name.

## Common hour-eaters to ask about

### Live load / unload

Driver waits while freight is loaded: 1–3 h, sometimes more.

### Detention history

“How long do they usually take?” Brokers often know.

### Big cities

Traffic in LA, Chicago, NYC, Atlanta can double the time.

### Weather & mountains

Snow, wind, grades: slower average speed.

# Before you say “yes” to a load

## The driver

- Where is he now, and when will he be empty?
- Drive hours, shift hours, break due, cycle hours **right now**
- When does his 10-hour rest end?
- Home-time plans, personal limits (e.g. no night driving)

## The load

- Pickup window: appointment or FCFS? Live load or drop?
- Miles from the truck to pickup (deadhead) + loaded miles
- Delivery window and **time zone**
- Known delays: detention history, city, weather, mountains

## The calculation

- Drive time = miles ÷ 50
- + 30-min breaks · + 10-h rests · + stop time · + buffer
- ETA converted to the receiver's zone
- Buffer of at least 1–2 hours?



### Say it out loud — the honest ETA

**“With a solo driver, loading at 9 Central, I can have him in Charlotte around 2 PM Eastern Thursday, but that’s tight. Could the receiver take him at 4, or first come first served?”**



### Deadhead counts too

The drive from where the truck is now to the pickup uses the same clocks. A load 150 miles away costs 3 hours of driving before loading even starts.

# What a dispatcher must never do

## Safety first: what a dispatcher may and may not do

FMCSA's coercion rule (49 CFR 390.6) bars motor carriers, shippers, receivers and brokers from coercing drivers to break safety rules.

### Good dispatchers

- ✓ Check the driver's clocks before offering a load
- ✓ Plan the trip with the driver, not for him
- ✓ Accept "I'm out of hours" or "it's not safe" as a final answer
- ✓ Tell the broker early if the plan changes
- ✓ Keep messages professional — they are records

### Never

- ✗ "Just run it, nobody will know"
- ✗ Asking a driver to edit or fake his logs
- ✗ Using personal conveyance to move a load forward
- ✗ Pushing through dangerous weather or fatigue
- ✗ Threatening pay, loads or the job to force a trip

You act for the carrier: coercion by a dispatcher can expose the carrier to penalties, and falsified logs are illegal. A tired driver in an 80,000-lb truck is the biggest risk in this business.

## The coercion rule

49 CFR 390.6: a motor carrier, shipper, receiver or transportation intermediary (and their agents) may not coerce a driver to operate a truck in violation of the safety rules, including hours of service. FMCSA's rule came into force in 2016, and drivers can report coercion to FMCSA.

As the carrier's dispatcher you are acting for the carrier. A message like "Just run it, nobody will know" is exactly the evidence an investigator looks for.



### Falsified logs

Editing, faking or "fixing" records of duty status to hide violations is illegal for the driver and the carrier. ELDs keep an audit trail of every edit. If a trip only works with a false log, **it doesn't work**.



**Your script when the driver says no**  
**"Understood — safety first. I'll let the broker know and re-plan."** Then do exactly that, early.

# Twenty booking cases (1–12)

For each: **yes / no / only if**, plus the reason in one line and the calculation where needed. Use miles ÷ 50 for driving time. Answers at the back.

**1** Truck 12 has **3:00 of drive time** left. The pickup is **180 miles** away. Can he reach it today?

**2** The driver has **5 hours** left on his 70-hour cycle. Tomorrow's load needs about 9 hours on duty. Can you book it?

**3** On duty at **06:00**, waited at the shipper, loaded at **13:00**. How many hours can he still drive today?

**4** The driver has driven **8 hours straight** and is 60 miles from the receiver. Can he keep driving?

**5** Drove 5 h, then 45 minutes loading. How many more hours can he drive today, and does he need another break first?

**6** Solo, **1,100 miles**, pickup Mon 8:00 AM, delivery Tue 5:00 PM, same time zone, 1 h loading. Feasible?

**7** Dallas pickup Mon 7:00 AM CT (1.5 h loading), Atlanta delivery Tue **8:00 AM ET**, 780 miles. Feasible?

**8** A broker says: "Your driver can do 600 miles today, right?" What do you answer?

**9** The driver says: "I can make it if I fix my log later." What do you do?

**10** A local box-truck carrier runs within about 80 miles of its yard and is back each evening. How might its drivers record hours?

**11** Unexpected heavy snow slowed the driver. He reaches his 11 hours 30 minutes from delivery. What are the options?

**12** The driver's 10-hour rest ends at **04:00 CT**. The pickup appointment is **05:00 CT**, 40 miles away. OK?

# Twenty booking cases (13–20)

**13** Laredo pickup Mon 8:00 AM; the broker wants Chicago delivery **Wed 8:00 AM**. Solo driver. Answer?

**14** It is 23:00 PKT in October. The driver's window closes at 17:00 CT. How much window is left?

**15** Delivery at 06:00 ET, 250 miles away. The driver's rest ends at 01:00 ET and pre-trip takes 15 minutes. On time?

**16** The driver has been held **4 hours** at the shipper. Tomorrow's delivery assumed a full driving day today. What do you do?

**17** The driver wants to use his 3-hour wait as part of a sleeper-berth split. Who decides, and what do you do?

**18** The load requires team service. Your carrier has only solo drivers. Book it?

**19** The driver has used his 11 hours, but 2 hours remain in his 14-hour window. Can he fuel and do paperwork?

**20** A broker offers a \$200 bonus "if your driver gets there a few hours earlier than he legally can." Your answer?



## Target

At least **17 of 20**. If you miss any HOS case, re-read pages 4–10. If you miss a time-zone case, revisit Module 3.



## Say it out loud — drill 6: refusing an unsafe request politely

Broker: "Can't your guy just push through tonight?"

**"I understand the timing is tight. He's out of hours at 8 PM Central and needs his 10-hour break, so the realistic delivery is 10 AM tomorrow. I can send you a tracking update when he's rolling. Would 10 AM work for the receiver?"**

Calm, factual, and offering a solution. Practise until it sounds natural.

# Module 4 check

1. State the 11-hour, 14-hour, 30-minute and 60/70-hour rules in your own words.
2. Does the 14-hour window stop while the driver waits at a dock? Why does that matter?
3. What counts as the 30-minute break?
4. What resets the weekly cycle completely?
5. Describe the sleeper-berth split and one pairing that works.
6. What was wrong with “600 legal miles / 10 hr” in the old manual?
7. Which planning speed does this module use, and roughly how many miles is a full solo driving day?
8. Name four things an ELD records automatically or displays to the dispatcher.
9. What must a driver do if his ELD malfunctions?
10. Which time zone does a driver’s log use?
11. What is coercion under 49 CFR 390.6, and who can be responsible?
12. An ETA shows arrival 20 minutes before the appointment. What is your decision and what do you say?



## **ELD malfunctions (49 CFR 395.34)**

If the ELD malfunctions, the driver must note it, give the carrier written notice within 24 hours, reconstruct his records for the current 24 hours and the previous 7 days, and keep paper logs until it is fixed. The carrier must repair or replace it within 8 days, unless FMCSA grants an extension.

# Answers — booking cases

- 1**     **No.**  $180 \div 50 = 3.6$  h of driving > 3:00 left.
- 2**     **No** (as planned). 5 h of cycle < 9 h needed. Plan a 34-h restart, or a smaller load.
- 3**     Until the window closes at 20:00 → **7 hours** ( $\approx 350$  mi). The long wait already counts as his break.
- 4**     **No**, not until he takes a 30-minute break.
- 5**     **6 more hours** ( $11 - 5$ ), window permitting. No break needed first: the 45-min loading reset the 8-hour count.
- 6**     **No as posted.** Day 1: depart 9:00, 550 mi by 20:30; rest to 06:30. Day 2: 550 mi + break →  $\approx 18:00$ , an hour late, before unloading. Ask for a later delivery, or it needs a team.
- 7**     **No.** Day 1:  $\approx 550$  mi by 20:00 CT; rest to 06:00. Remaining 230 mi = 4.6 h → 10:36 CT = **11:36 AM ET**. Ask for noon ET or later.
- 8**     “For a solo driver we plan 500–550 miles on a full driving day, and less on pickup day. Here’s a realistic ETA...”
- 9**     Refuse. Falsifying logs is illegal. Re-plan honestly and tell the broker.
- 10**    Possibly the **short-haul exception** (150 air miles, back within 14 h): time records instead of logs/ELD. The carrier confirms which drivers qualify.
- 11**    The **adverse driving conditions** rule may allow up to 2 more hours for unexpected conditions. **The driver decides** whether it applies and is safe; you don’t pressure.
- 12**    **Yes, but tight.** Pre-trip  $\sim 15$  min + 40 mi  $\approx 0.8$  h → about 05:05. Ask the shipper whether a few minutes late is acceptable, or plan the rest to end earlier next time.
- 13**    **No.**  $\sim 1,430$  mi = 3 solo driving days; the earliest is Wed  $\sim 12:30$  CT. Offer Wed afternoon, or it needs a team.
- 14**    October: PKT = CT + 10, so 23:00 PKT = 13:00 CT → **4 hours** of window left.
- 15**    **No.**  $01:15 + 5$  h = 06:15 ET, 15 min late. Ask for 07:00 or FCFS.
- 16**    Recalculate with the hours actually left, and **tell the broker early** with a new ETA. Document the detention (Module 10).
- 17**    **The driver** (and his ELD). Once he confirms the split, you plan around it.
- 18**    **No.** Don’t book team freight without a real team.
- 19**    **Yes.** Other on-duty work is allowed; only driving is not, until 10 hours off.
- 20**    Decline. It invites an HOS violation (coercion risk) and endangers the driver and the public.

# Answers — module check

- 1** 11 h driving after 10 h off; no driving after the 14th hour on duty; 30-min break after 8 cumulative hours of driving; no driving after 60 h / 7 days or 70 h / 8 days on duty.
- 2** No. Waiting eats the window, so the driver loses driving hours and the next appointment may fail.
- 3** Any 30 consecutive minutes not driving: off duty, sleeper, on-duty-not-driving (e.g. loading), or a mix.
- 4** A 34-hour (or longer) off-duty restart.
- 5**  $\geq 7$  h in the sleeper +  $\geq 2$  h off duty or sleeper, total  $\geq 10$  h (e.g. 7/3 or 8/2). Paired correctly, neither period counts against the 14-hour window.
- 6** The law limits hours, not miles, and 600 miles in 10 h requires a 60 mph average: unrealistic without speeding or violations.
- p.7**  $11 + 12 + 10 + 13 + 0 + 9 + 11 = 66$  h, so  $70 - 66 =$  **4 hours** today.
- 7** 50 mph → about 500–550 miles on a full driving day.
- 8** Any four: duty status, driving time, location, engine hours/miles, remaining drive/shift/break/cycle time.
- 9** Note it, notify the carrier in writing within 24 h, reconstruct the current day + previous 7 days, keep paper logs until repaired.
- 10** The time standard of the driver's home terminal.
- 11** Forcing a driver to break safety rules (e.g. HOS). Motor carriers, shippers, receivers and transportation intermediaries (and their agents) can be responsible.
- 12** Only if. Ask the broker for a later window or FCFS; tell the carrier the risk. A 20-minute buffer is not enough.

# Glossary

**11-hour limit** — Maximum driving after 10 consecutive hours off.

**14-hour window** — Period after coming on duty; no driving after its end.

**30-minute break** — Required after 8 cumulative hours of driving.

**34-hour restart** — 34+ consecutive hours off duty that resets the 60/70 cycle.

**60/70-hour cycle** — On-duty limit over 7 or 8 consecutive days.

**Adverse driving conditions** — Unexpected conditions allowing up to 2 extra hours.

**Coercion** — Forcing a driver to break safety rules; banned by 49 CFR 390.6.

**Cycle hours** — On-duty hours left in the 7/8-day period.

**Deadhead** — Empty miles to reach a pickup; uses the same clocks.

**Drive time left** — ELD figure: driving hours remaining today.

**ELD** — Electronic logging device recording duty status.

**FCFS** — First come, first served: a window instead of a fixed time.

**HOS** — Hours of service: federal driver work-time rules.

**Home terminal time** — Time standard used on the driver's log.

**Live load / unload** — Driver waits while freight is loaded or unloaded.

**Off duty** — Not working.

**On duty (not driving)** — Working but not driving: loading, inspections, waiting.

**Personal conveyance** — Off-duty personal use of the truck; never to advance a load.

**RODS** — Record of duty status (the log).

**Short-haul exception** — 150 air miles / 14 h: time records instead of logs.

**Shift left** — Time remaining in the 14-hour window.

**Sleeper berth** — Rest in the truck's sleeping compartment.

**Split sleeper** — 7+ h sleeper + 2+ h rest = the 10-hour rest.

**Team** — Two drivers taking turns so the truck keeps moving.

**Yard move** — On-duty movement inside a yard.

# Sources and planning notes

| Source        | Document                                                                                                                                              | Where                                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| FMCSA         | Summary of Hours of Service Regulations (property-carrying: 11, 14, 30-min break, 60/70, 34-h restart, sleeper split, adverse conditions, short-haul) | <a href="https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/regulations/hours-service/summary-hours-service-regulations">fmcsa.dot.gov/regulations/hours-service/summary-hours-service-regulations</a> |
| FMCSA         | FMCSA Advances Hours of Service Pilot Programs (27 Aug 2026): flexible sleeper berth + split duty period; 2027 launch, 512 drivers                    | <a href="https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/newsroom">fmcsa.dot.gov/newsroom</a>                                                                                                       |
| FMCSA         | General Information about the ELD Rule (who must use ELDs; exceptions)                                                                                | <a href="https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/hours-service/elds">fmcsa.dot.gov/hours-service/elds</a>                                                                                   |
| eCFR          | 49 CFR 395.34 — ELD malfunctions (24-h notice, reconstruct 7 days, repair within 8 days)                                                              | <a href="https://www.ecfr.gov">ecfr.gov</a>                                                                                                                                   |
| eCFR          | 49 CFR 395.8(f)(8) — logs use the home-terminal time standard                                                                                         | <a href="https://www.ecfr.gov">ecfr.gov</a>                                                                                                                                   |
| eCFR          | 49 CFR 390.6 — Coercion prohibited                                                                                                                    | <a href="https://www.ecfr.gov">ecfr.gov</a>                                                                                                                                   |
| FMCSA         | Personal conveyance guidance (2018)                                                                                                                   | <a href="https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov">fmcsa.dot.gov</a>                                                                                                                         |
| User-supplied | OMNITECH manual — ELD photo; legacy claim “600 legal miles / 10 hr” (corrected)                                                                       | your files                                                                                                                                                                    |



## Planning figures

The 50 mph average, 500–550 miles per full solo day and 1–2 hour buffers are **planning conventions** used by dispatchers, not legal rules. Always use the driver’s real clocks and conditions. Trip plans in this module are simplified: no traffic, fuel stops beyond the break, or pre-trip inspection time unless shown.



## Keep checking

HOS rules can change through rulemaking, and the 2027 pilot programs may lead to changes later. Re-check FMCSA’s HOS page before relying on any detail in a new situation.